

Dear Editors:

We would like to submit the enclosed manuscript entitled **“Leadership and Decision Making in Digitally Transforming Enterprises: Multivariate Modeling and Cluster Typologies of Decision Agility and Young Managerial Advancement”**, which we wish to be considered for publication in *Systems* for the Special Issue **“Navigating Digital Transformation: Leadership and Decision Making in Today’s Systems.”**

No conflict of interest exists in the submission of this manuscript, and the manuscript is approved by all authors for publication. I would like to declare on behalf of my co-authors that the work described was original research that has not been published previously and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere, in whole or in part. All authors listed have approved the manuscript that is enclosed.

This study investigates how the leadership and decision-making practices of digitally transforming enterprises relate to organizational decision agility and to the advancement of young people into management. Drawing on an executive survey of 285 firms in China's Yangtze River Delta, we measure four practices—digital transformation leadership, the breadth of AI-assisted managerial decision-making, decision-process digitalization, and the involvement of young employees in transformation decisions—and relate them to decision agility and to the share of managerial positions held by employees aged 35 or younger. Combining MANOVA-type multivariate modeling, exploratory factor analysis, and hierarchical plus k-means clustering, the study offers a system-level account of how digital transformation is steered inside enterprises, and by whom.

The innovations of this paper are as follows.

(1) This study places leadership and decision making—the core of the Special Issue—at the center of the empirical design. Rather than treating digital transformation as technology adoption, we model the decision system of the enterprise: who leads it, how broadly AI assists it, how deeply the decision process is digitalized, and who participates in it.

(2) This study documents a complementary asymmetry between technology and participation in decision systems. The breadth of AI-assisted decision-making is significantly associated with decision agility but only marginally with young managerial presence, whereas institutionalized involvement of young employees shows the reverse pattern; transformation leadership and digitalized decision processes accompany both outcomes. A single latent leadership–decision configuration underlies the four practices and is significantly associated with agility and with managerial rejuvenation.

(3) This study identifies two socio-technical decision regimes that cut across sectors. An agile, digitally led regime with a distinctly younger management corps contrasts with a conventional hierarchical regime; the regimes barely differ in sectoral composition, indicating that decision regimes reflect organizational choice rather than industry environment—an insight directly relevant to leadership audiences navigating digital transformation.

We believe that this manuscript fits well within the scope of *Systems* and the Special Issue “Navigating Digital Transformation: Leadership and Decision Making in Today’s Systems”. The paper addresses the Special Issue's three focal themes in a single design—the role of leadership in driving digital initiatives, the strategies and processes of decision making in the digital age, and the impact of digital transformation on organizational structures and practices—and does so with a systems methodology that examines direct associations, a latent configuration, and emergent typologies. The findings offer actionable implications for executives and policymakers concerned with agile, generationally renewed organizations.

We sincerely appreciate your consideration of our manuscript and look forward to receiving comments from the reviewers.

We deeply appreciate your consideration of our manuscript and look forward to receiving comments from the reviewers. Correspondence should be directed to Xinyu Cai at the following address:

Degree: Ph.D.

Institution and address: College of Business, Jiaxing University; Jiaxing 314001, China;

Email: caixinyu@zjxu.edu.cn

Thanks very much for your attention to our paper.

Very sincerely yours,

Xinyu Cai